BERNSTEIN
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Global Semiconductors & Hardware

China Smartphone Tracker (June): Lower yet still some inventory risk

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*Please download our smartphone monthly tracker data from **here**.*

Sell-through rebounded 62% MoM thanks to the "618" promotions. In June, China smartphone sell-through reached 28M units, up 62% MoM and 3% YoY, making 6M26 cumulative shipment fall by 7%. Memory price made low-tier shipment fall 14% in June, but mid- & high-tier segments combined managed to grow c. 10% YoY thanks to promotions of Huawei & other Android brands. The contribution from entry-level models in the overall shipment mix stayed at a record low in June.

Apple still expanded unit share YoY, but not as much as in May as others also had promotions. Discounts on iPhone 17 Pro drove a rapid share gain in May. That likely pulled some demand forward & in June rivals had promotions in RMB 3-5K price band too. Apple thus saw its share narrowed MoM. Huawei's premium shipment was flat MoM, suggesting the higher SoC costs from SMIC's "N+3" node limits Huawei's ability to compete on price.

Destocking efforts by Android brands brought inventory lower yet still elevated. Chinese OEMs increased promotions in the RMB3-5K price segment, likely to digest inventory ahead of September product launches. Sell-in was thus lower than sell-through, reducing inventory from 3.9 months in May to 3.2 sequentially but still above normal levels.

ASP normalized MoM but was still 15% higher YoY. June ASP moderated from the high base in May, likely reflecting pulled-forward iPhone demand. ASP nonetheless remained materially above prior-year levels, supported by like-for-like price increases & a lower mix of entry-level. This, coupled with the reported SoC price hike by both ***Qualcomm*** and ***MediaTek***, keeps us caution on further demand destruction in 2H26 and possibly in 2027.

Memory squeezing low-end segment is a headwind against MediaTek, but gain at mid-tier & Xiaomi & Honor has been keeping MediaTek's market share resilient. We rate MediaTek Outperform (*report*, *model*). We currently forecast the ASIC revenue to be US $2B, 15B and 22B in 2026–2028, respectively, but see an upside risk to it, especially in 2028. Rapid growth in TPU revenue and high operating leverage should be more than enough to offset smartphone weakness. Outperform.

We rate Apple Outperform as share gains continue (see recent APPLE TRACKER and AAPL FQ3'26: Memflation takes a bite out of the Apple for more on our latest thoughts on Apple). For suppliers in smartphone value chain, Luxshare and Largan should be more resilient than Sunny Optical this year, supported by stronger Apple exposure (vs. Android) and ongoing progress in AI-related products.

Xiaomi's (OP) shipments declined by -18% YoY, with market share falling to 12.9%, vs. 14.5% in May 2026 and 16.2% in June 2025. Other than high base, the weakness partially reflects its premiumization strategy amid rising memory prices. In 2026 6M, shipments of high-end models (RMB 4k+) declined by -21% YoY. Meanwhile, low-end (<RMB 2k) segments saw declines of -30% YoY. Xiaomi's 12-month rolling ASP in China grew 7% YoY.

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	3 Aug 2026 Closing Price	Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Cur	Reported EPS 2025A	Reported EPS 2026E	Reported EPS 2027E	Reported P/E (x) 2025A	Reported P/E (x) 2026E	Reported P/E (x) 2027E
2454.TT (MediaTek)	O	TWD	3,910.00	4,380.00	163.3%	TWD	66.17	69.52	170.50	59.1	56.2	22.9
3034.TT (Novatek)	M	TWD	519.00	480.00	(20.7)%	TWD	26.87	30.43	32.54	19.3	17.1	15.9
QCOM (Qualcomm)	M	USD	151.57	165.00	(19.6)%	USD	12.03	10.51	9.57	12.6	14.4	15.8
SOI.FP (Soitec)	O	EUR	109.30	180.00	174.4%	EUR	(6.17)	0.28	2.49	(17.7)	396.5	43.8
002475.CH (Luxshare)	O	CNY	53.71	86.00	17.5%	CNY	2.26	2.66	3.45	23.8	20.2	15.6
3008.TT (Largan)	O	TWD	3,960.00	5,150.00	35.7%	TWD	158.08	187.55	208.38	25.0	21.1	19.0
1810.HK (Xiaomi)	O	HKD	27.96	43.00	(70.6)%	CNY	1.62	1.02	1.77	14.8	23.6	13.6
AAPL (Apple)	O	USD	303.42	370.00	28.1%	USD	7.46	8.85	10.03	40.7	34.3	30.3
2382.HK (Sunny Optical)	O	HKD	56.55	94.00	(53.8)%	CNY	4.25	3.44	4.52	11.5	14.1	10.8
ASIAX			1,897.76									
SPX			7,600.50									
EDME			1,618.74									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

QCOM, SOI.FP, AAPL estimate is Adjusted EPS; QCOM, SOI.FP, AAPL valuation is Adjusted P/E (x); SOI.FP base year is 2026;

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

MediaTek (OP, PT NT$4,380.00): We rate MediaTek Outperform with PT NT$4,380.00.

Novatek (MP, PT NT$480.00): We rate Novatek Market-Perform with PT NT$480.00.

Apple (OP, PT$370): We rate AAPL Outperform with PT $370.00.

QCOM (MP, $165): The diversification story is real but a number of near-term headwinds (smartphone memory dynamics, margins, AAPL etc) need to be navigated first.

Luxshare (OP, PT RMB 86.00): We rate Luxshare Outperform with a RMB86.00 price target.

Sunny Optical (OP, PT HK$94.00): We rate Sunny Optical Outperform with a HK$94.00 price target.

Largan (MP, PT NT$ 5,150.00): We rate Largan Outperform with a NT$5,150.00 price target.

Soitec (Outperform, PT €180.00). We rate Soitec Outperform with a PT of €180.00. RF-SOI (60% of revenue) remains under pressure from foundry de-stocking; Soitec's core narrative is shifting to Photonics-SOI as the next primary source of growth.

Xiaomi (Outperform, PT HK$43): We rate Xiaomi Outperform with price target for 1810.HK at HK$43.00.

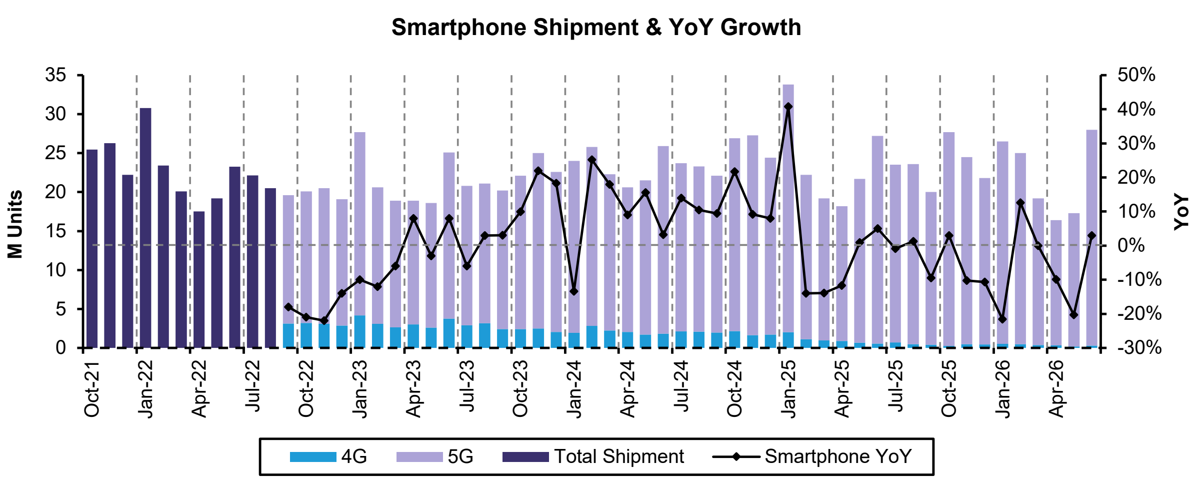
DETAILS

This tracker is mainly based on the smartphone sell-through data that CINNO reports for the China market. We also compare that with the sell-in data published by CATR to help investors get a view on handset inventory. Additionally, we summarize the shares of mobile SoC suppliers & the use of display panel technologies. Please find the details of our methodology in **this** and **this report**.

China smartphone sell-through rebounded 62% MoM thanks to the "618" promotions in June.

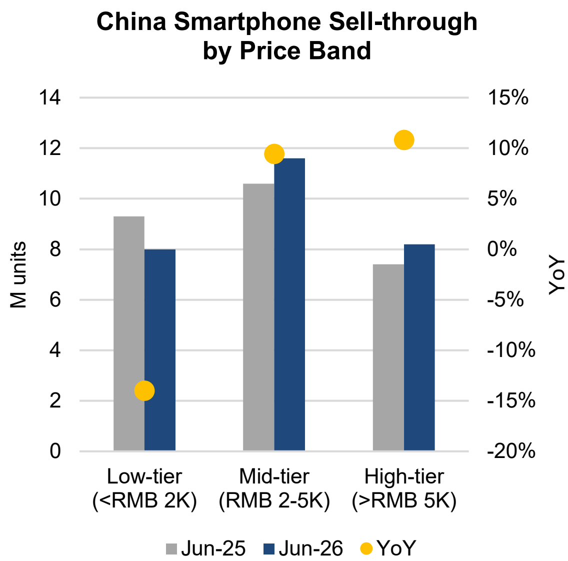
- In June, China smartphone sell-through reached 28M units, up 62% MoM driven by the "618 Shopping Festival". June was up 3% YoY on single-month basis (Exhibit 1), but the cumulative shipment in 6M26 was still down 7%.
- And by price tier, low-end segment continued suffering from high memory cost. Should we define low-tier segment as smartphones priced below RMB 2,000 (below c. US$290), mid-tier as RMB 2,000-5,000 (c. US$290-725) and high-tier as above RMB 5,000 (above c. US$725), we find a clear divergence across these segments. The low-end segment saw its shipments decline 14% YoY in June — significantly underperforming the overall market. The mid-tier segment and high-tier segments were both more resilient, up 9% and 11% YoY, respectively, partly thanks to the seasonal mix upgrade from the "618" promotions (Exhibit 2). As a result, the contribution from low-end segment in the overall shipment mix stayed at a record low in June (Exhibit 3).
- Premium OEMs like Huawei and Apple were less-affected by the memory cost pressure (Exhibit 4, Exhibit 5). In contrast, other OEMs saw their combined shipment decline 9% YoY in June & their aggregated market share drop 8.3pts (Exhibit 6 - Exhibit 7).
- We now forecast China smartphone market to 15% decline YoY this year (**Smartphone and 5G Model**). Sell-through data YTD also revealed the memory impact on handset shipment, but some foundries and component suppliers on the other hand have reported better-than-feared results thus far. We wonder if pulled-in inventory buildup may explain the divergence and delay the impact on foundries & upstream suppliers to 2H26 and 1H27 and will monitor the trend closely.

EXHIBIT 1: **China smartphone sell-through shipment in June was up 62% MoM and 3% YoY.**



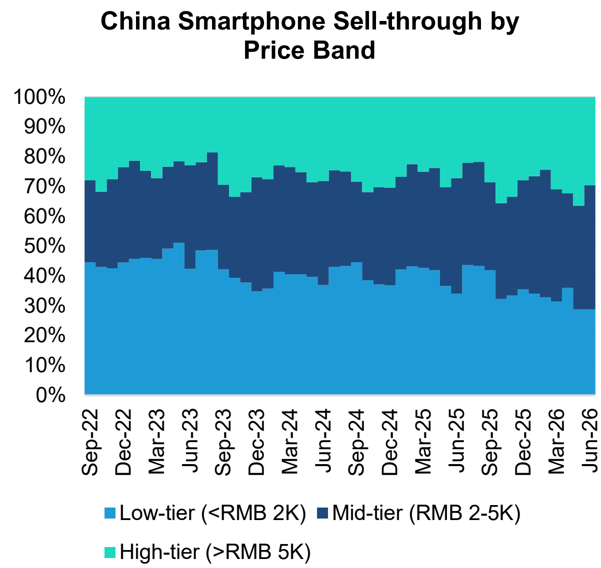
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **Low-tier smartphone shipment declined by 14% YoY in June, while mid-tier and high-tier shipment was up 9% and 11%, respectively.**



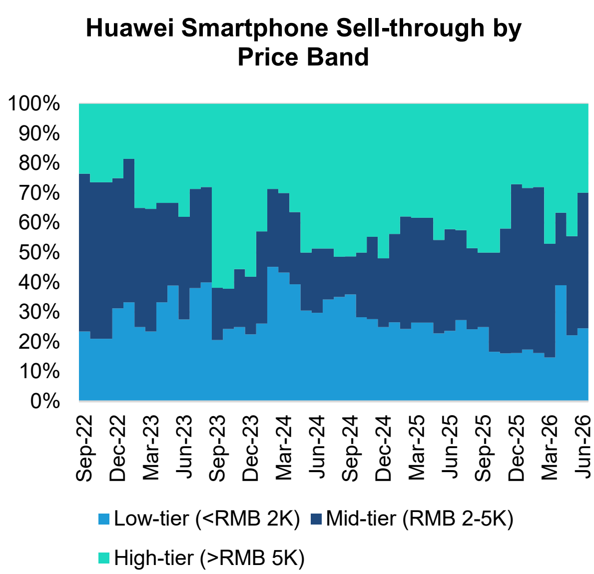
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **The contribution from low-end segment in the overall sales mix remained record low in June.**



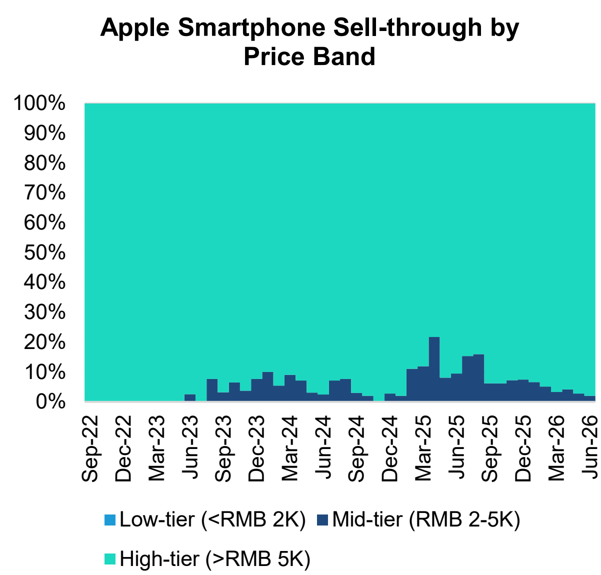
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: **For Huawei the fall of low-end segment mix started before memory price hike.**



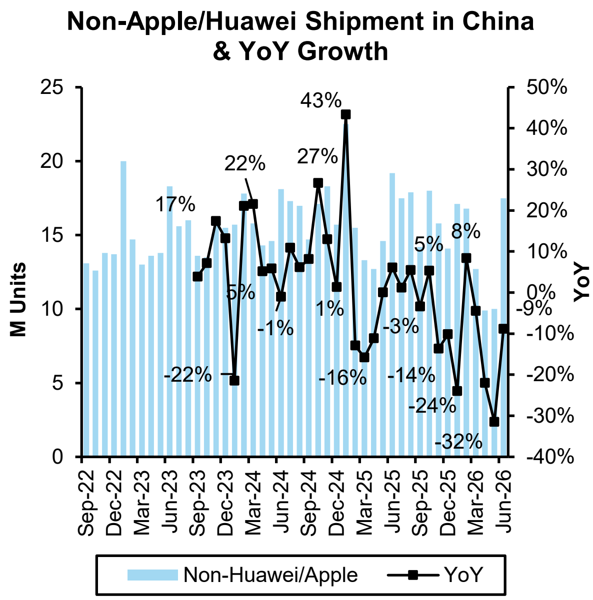
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 5: **Apple has no exposure to low-end market, and thus best positioned among all brands.**



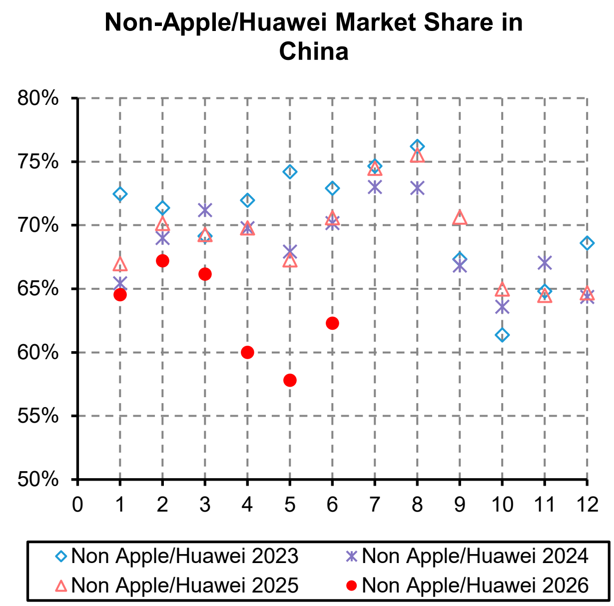
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 6: **Other OEMs together shipped 9% less smartphones in June 2026 vs. June 2025 ...**



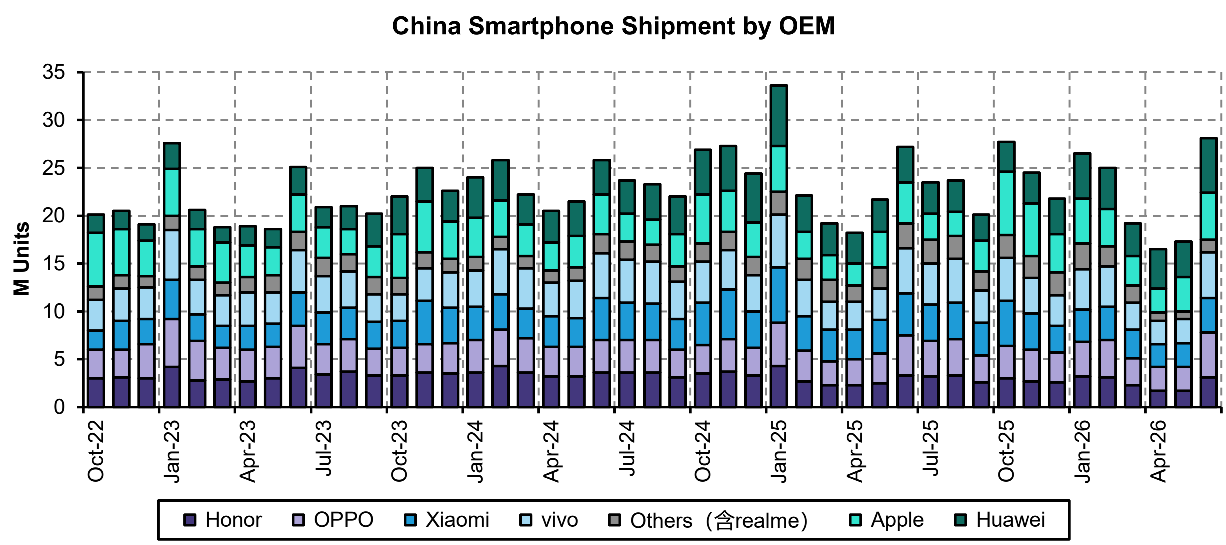
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: **...and they collectively lost 8.3pts unit share YoY, likely burdened by the drop of low-end segment shipment.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: **All OEMs improved their sell-through MoM in June. On a YoY base, Huawei and Apple grew most.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

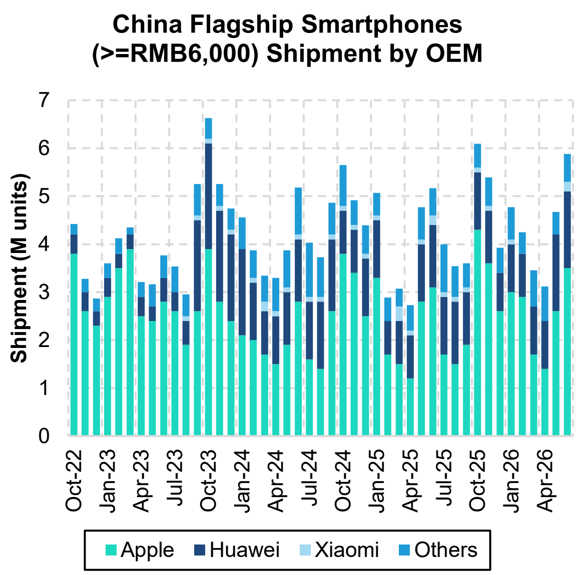
For Apple, the benefit of price discount waned in June & its market share slid MoM as competitors also had promtions.

- Huawei's adoption of homegrown SoCs from late 2023 helped it regain share in higher-end segments, and other Chinese OEMs also moved upward in price tiers and chipped away shares from the low-side of Apple's portfolio. With the size of flagship segment barely growing, Apple earlier lost share mainly to Huawei and to a lesser extent to other OEMs (Exhibit 9 - Exhibit 11).

- Apple then has responded with more flexible pricing. At the iPhone 17 launch in September 2025, Apple priced the devices below RMB 6,000 & made them eligible for subsidies. The prices of the iPhone 16 series were also adjusted accordingly. Apple also expanded the use of seasonal promotions across various distribution channels. Right at the beginning of this year's "618" season, Apple cut the price of iPhone 17 Pro by RMB1,000 and quickly gained 6pts unit share. However, this momentum however waned sequentially in June as competitors also had promotions, but Apple still managed to expand its unit share YoY by 7pts (Exhibit 12). See recent APPLE TRACKER and AAPL FQ3'26: Memflation takes a bite out of the Apple for more on our latest thoughts on Apple.

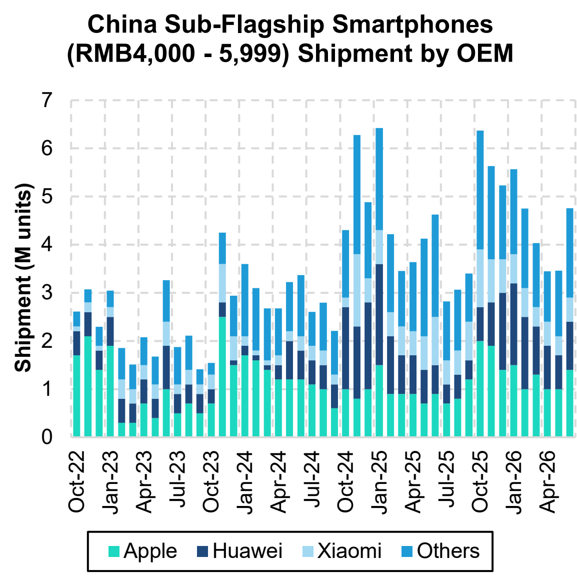
- Huawei's shipments grew 54% MoM and YoY in June, driven primarily by models priced between RMB3,000–5,000, while shipments in the premium segment remained largely flat. We focus on the Pura 90 Pro/Pro Max and Mate Pro Max models, which are powered by the Kirin 9030 chipset manufactured on SMIC's non-EUV N+3 node. Combined shipments of these models provide a useful gauge of both SMIC's N+3 capacity ramp and consumer demand for Huawei's latest flagship platform (Exhibit 13 - Exhibit 14). Early market reception to the Pura 90 series appears lukewarm. At the same time, elevated chip and memory costs limit Huawei's ability to compete aggressively on price. Apple, by contrast, retains greater pricing flexibility and has been more willing to use promotions to drive demand. This should not come as a surprise given teardown analysis indicating that SMIC's N+3 technology is broadly comparable to TSMC's N6 node and trails the industry's leading mobile process technologies by several years. More importantly, China's lack of EUV capability continues to place Huawei at a structural disadvantage versus Apple and other OEMs whose flagship smartphones benefit from more advanced EUV-based semiconductors.

EXHIBIT 9: **Apple focuses on flagship segment but the size of this segment hardly expanded.**



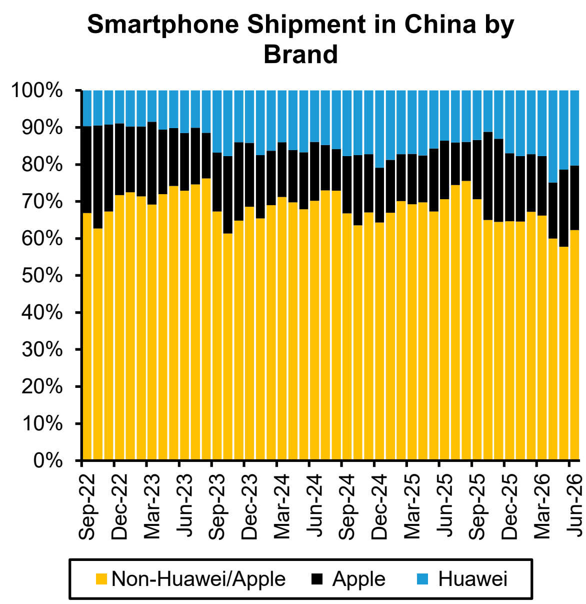
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 10: **In comparison, sub-flagship segment has been growing gradually.**



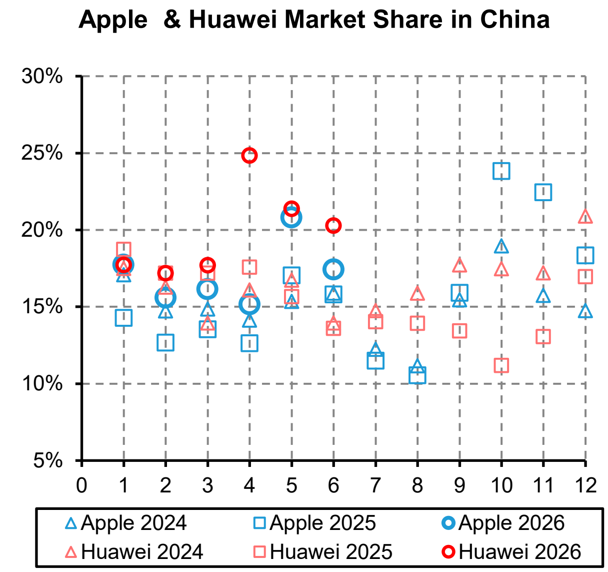
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 11: **Apple is challenged by Huawei in the flagship segment & earlier also by other Chinese OEMs in the sub-flagship segment.**



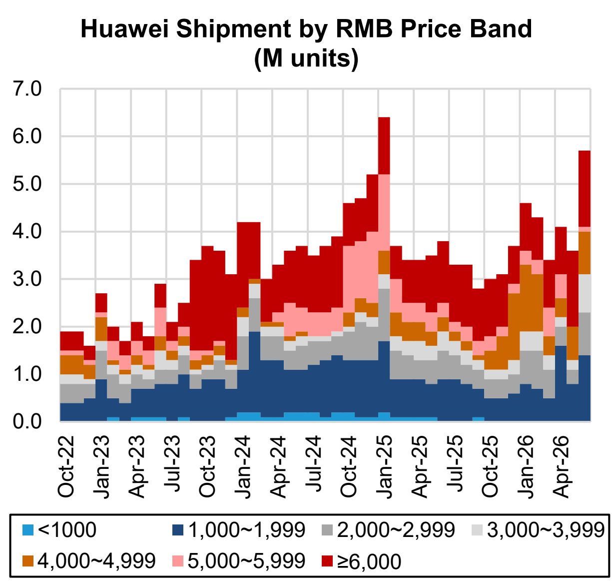
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 12: **In June, iPhone's unit share fell MoM but still expanded YoY.**



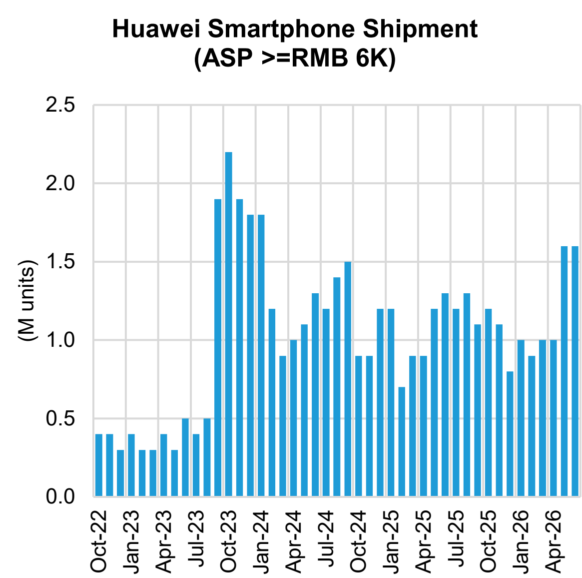
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 13: **Huawei's shipment increased by 54% sequentially in June but that was mainly driven by products with ASP below RMB 6K.**



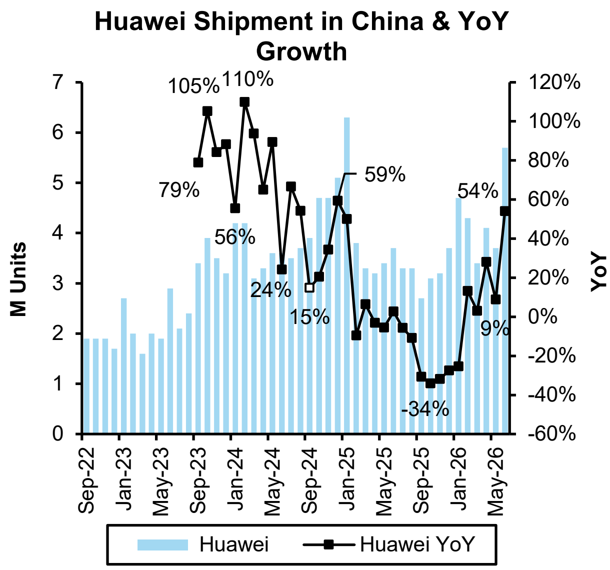
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 14: **In June, Huawei shipped the same amount of smartphones in the premium segment (i.e. ASP >= RMB 6K) MoM.**



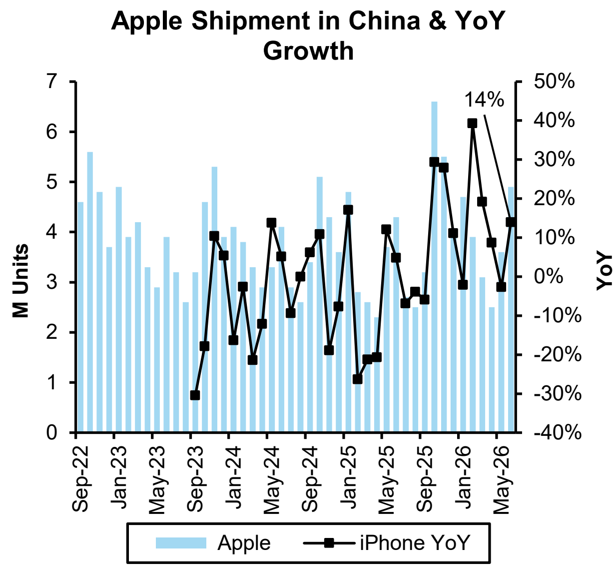
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 15: **Huawei's shipment increased by 54% YoY in June as it stepped up promotional efforts.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 16: **Apple shipment grew by 14% YoY in June.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

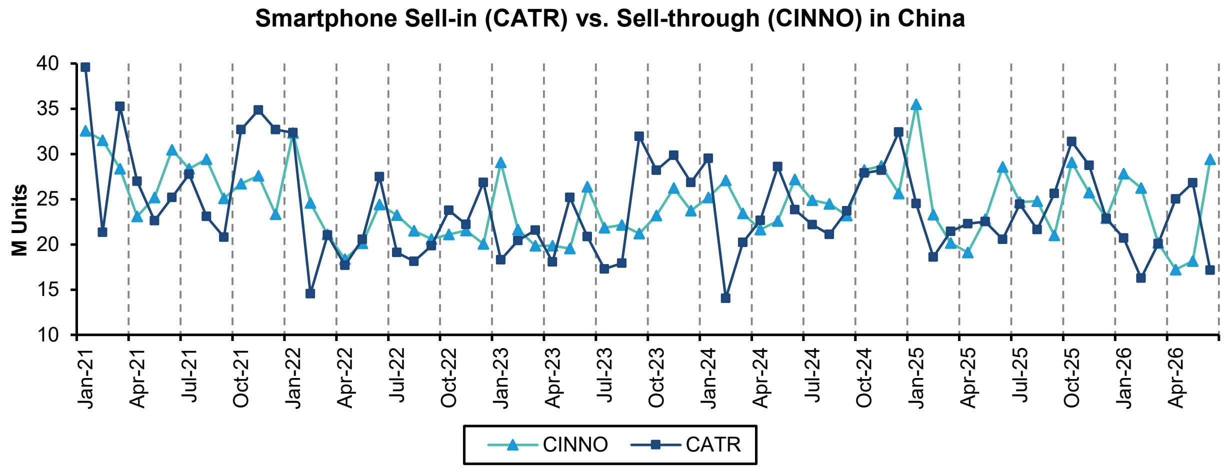
June sell-in notably lower than sell-through, suggesting de-stocking efforts particularly from Android brands

- History shows that obsolescence may make sell-in above sell-through by around 5% and our analysis makes an adjustment to reflect that (more details ***here***). With this adjustment, Exhibit 17 shows that June sell-in was lower than sell-through, particularly for Android brands (Exhibit 18). Inventory level has been brought down to 3.2 months from 3.9 months last month, but still higher than normal range of 1-2 months.

- Chinese OEMs increased promotions in the RMB3,000-5,000 price segment, likely to lower inventory ahead of September product launches.

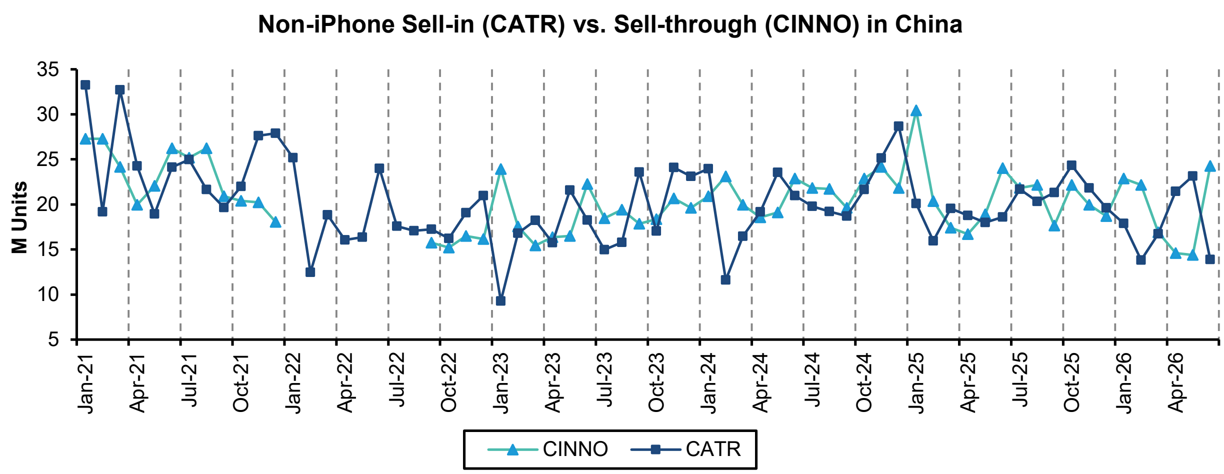
- On the other hand, iPhone had slightly lower sell-in vs. sell-through, but overall it maintains a healthy inventory level exiting June (Exhibit 19).

EXHIBIT 17: **Adjusting the sell-in data from CATR for possible obsolescence, we find sell-in was notably lower than sell-through in June...**



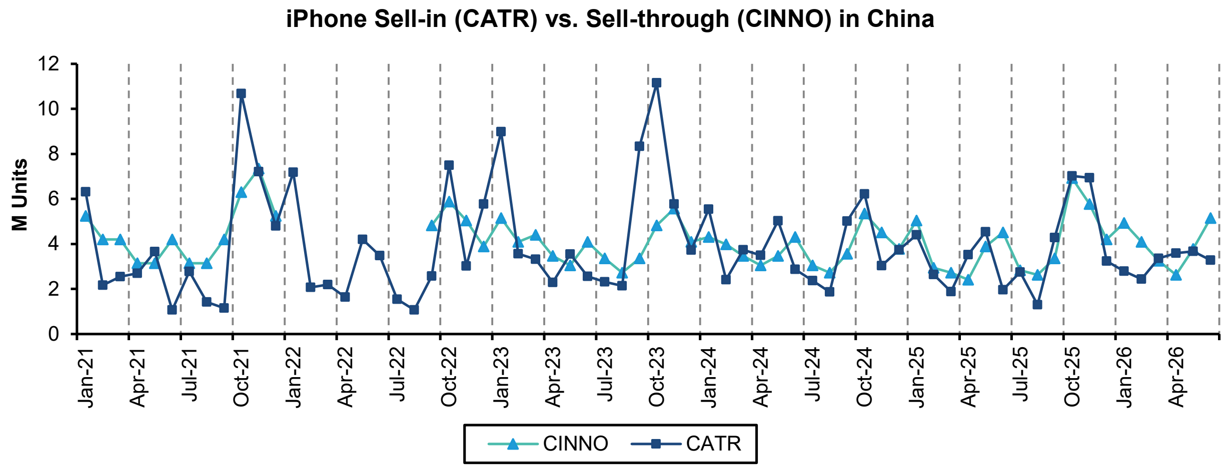
Source: CINNO, CATR, and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: **...suggesting de-stocking efforts particularly from Android brands.**



Source: CINNO, CATR, and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 19: **iPhone also saw slightly lower sell-in vs. sell-through, but overall it maintains a healthy inventory level exiting June**



Source: CINNO, CATR, and Bernstein analysis

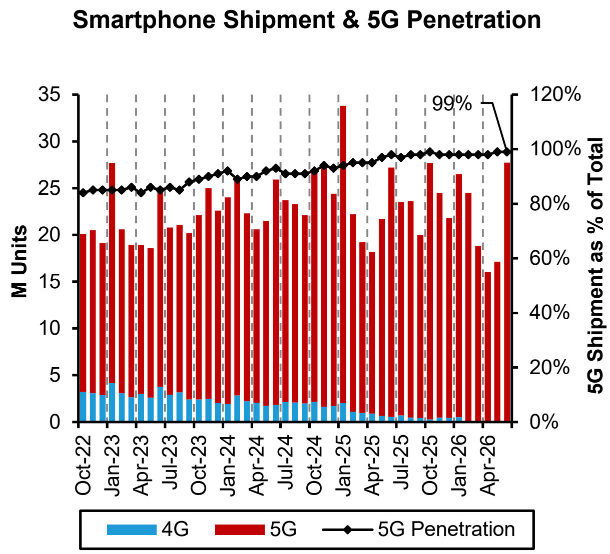
Smartphone ASP was still up 15% YoY. Coupled with the reported price hike of processor SoCs, we worry about demand destruction in 2H26 and possibly in 2027 too.

- High memory cost is prompting OEMs to cut low-priced models and raise prices elsewhere. Additionally, with 5G nearly fully adopted (Exhibit 20), many see smartphone market ex-growth and are hoping that Edge AI will bring it to growth again. Qualcomm also expects agentic AI to start benefiting the premium segment in fiscal year 2027. We hence monitor the mix of flagship (≥ US$850 (RMB 6,000)) & sub-flagship (US$560-850 (RMB 4,000-5,999)) segments, as well as the overall smartphone ASP, to gauge the effect of both considerations.

- In May ASP had an unusually strong increase thanks to the pulled-forward iPhone Pro shipment. This effect faded in June, but ASP remained 15% higher YoY, and materially above prior-year levels, supported by like-for-like price increases and memory constraining the shipment of entry-level models (Exhibit 21). Looking ahead, we expect ASP to remain elevated on YoY basis. Moreover, both Qualcomm and MediaTek are raising the price of their processor SoCs by double-digit %. We hence see likely more end demand destruction in 2H26 and possibly in 2027 too.

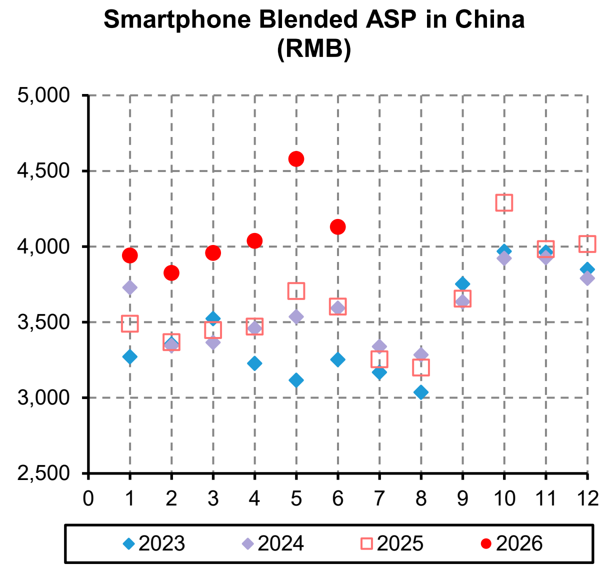
- Zooming into non-Apple/Huawei OEMs, we find their sub-flagship shipment still represented 14% of their total shipment, but the absolute volume was down 24% YoY in June (Exhibit 22, Exhibit 23). Flagship non-Apple/Huawei sales volume was up 2% YoY and its market share was also slightly higher vs. one year ago (Exhibit 24, Exhibit 25). As Apple and Huawei both turned more aggressive in flagship/sub-flagship segment during this "618 Shopping Festival", it's challenging for other OEMs to get sufficient revenue from flagship & sub-flagship segments to offset the loss in lower-end segments.

EXHIBIT 20: **5G penetration has reached almost 100% in new smartphone sales in China.**



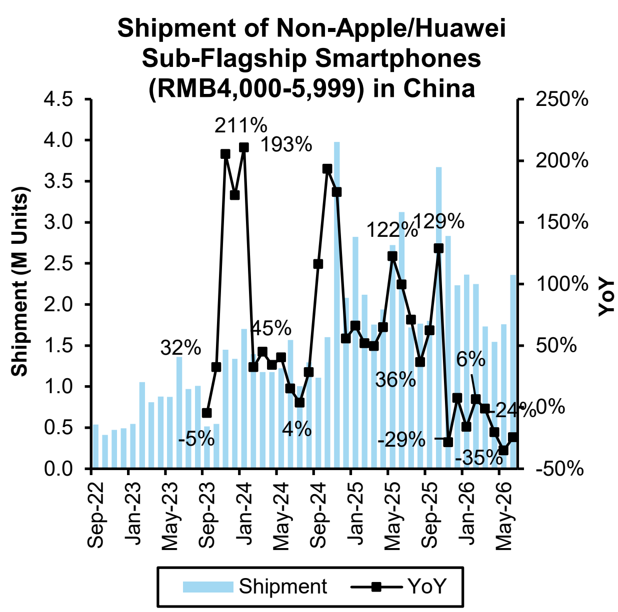
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 21: **Smartphone ASP normalized from the high base in May but was still up 15% YoY.**



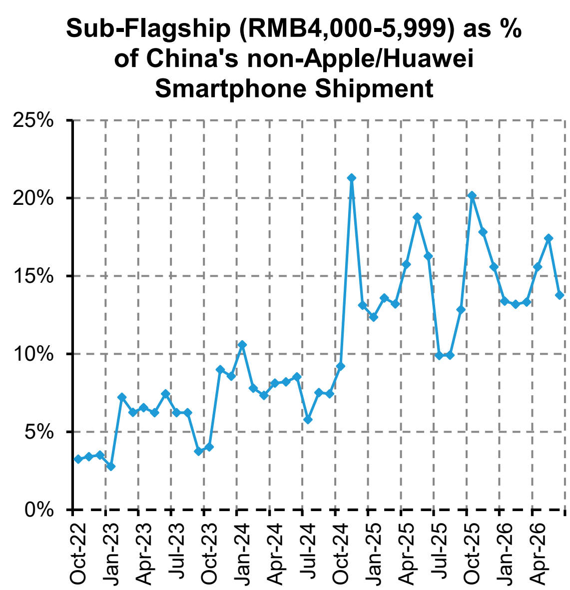
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 22: **Non-Apple/Huawei sub-flagship shipment was down 24% YoY in June.**



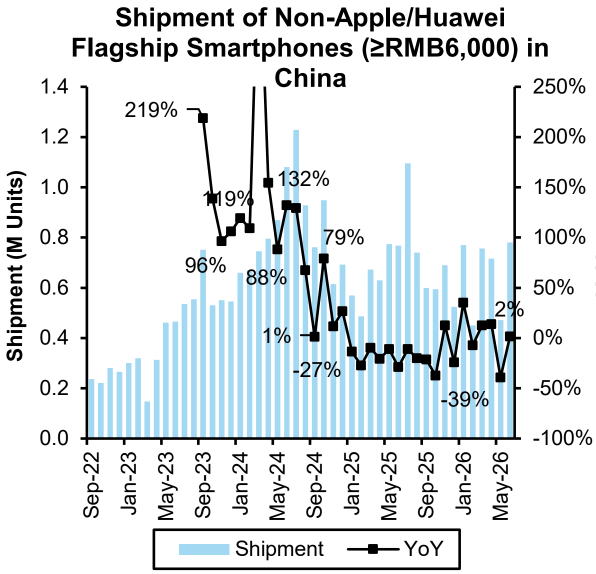
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 23: **Sub-flagship segment took up 14% of non-Apple/Huawei shipment, down 2pts YoY.**



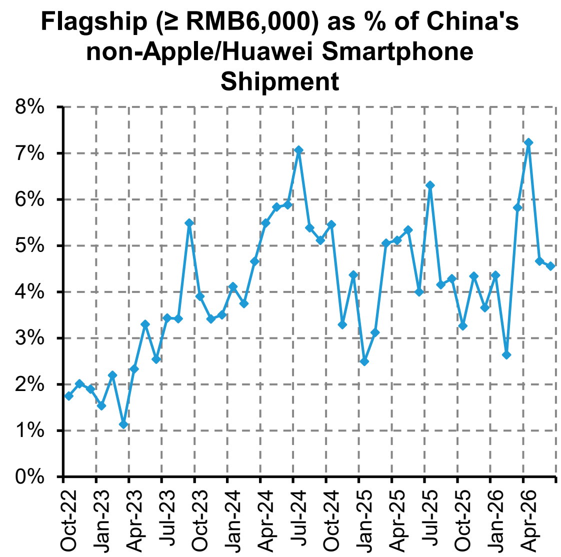
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 24: **Non-Apple/Huawei flagship shipment was up 2% YoY.**



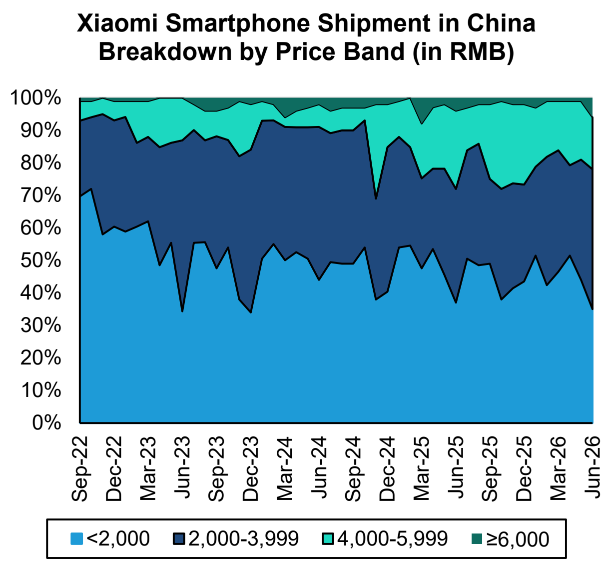
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 25: **Flagship segment accounted for c. 5% of total non-Apple/Huawei shipment, 1pt higher YoY.**



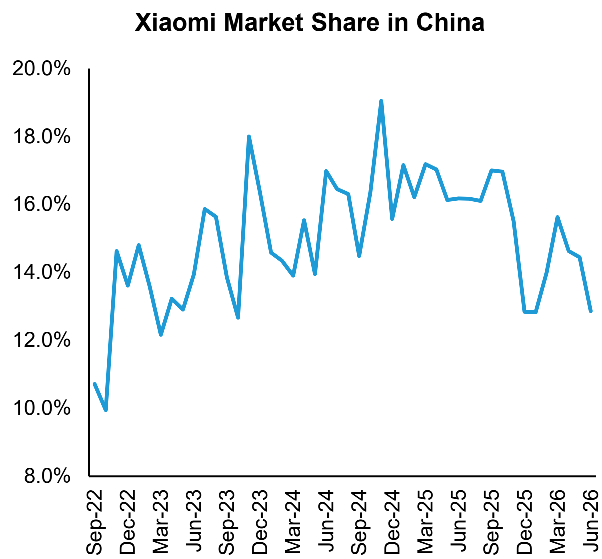
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 26: **The share of Xiaomi's shipments priced above RMB 4k increased MoM to 22%, while shipments priced below RMB 2k reached 35%, vs. 44% in May 2026**



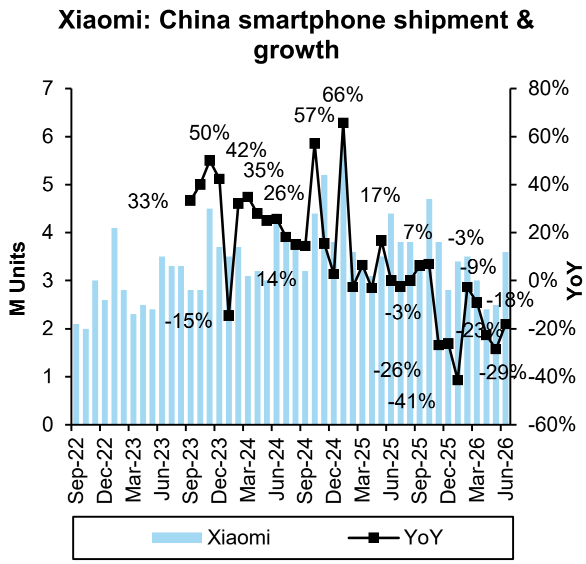
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 27: **In June 2026, Xiaomi's market share declined to 12.9% from 14.5% in May 2026 and 16.2% in June 2025.**



Source: CIINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 28: **Xiaomi's growth fell -18% YoY.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

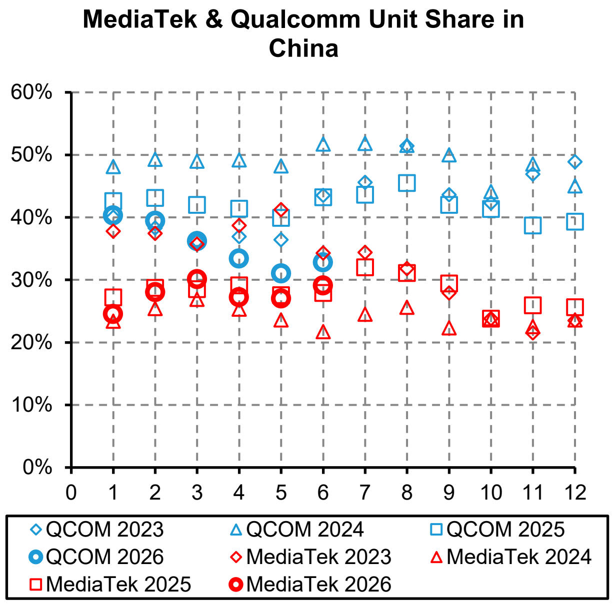
MediaTek defied the headwind from memory and has been keeping its market share resilient YTD.

- In June, unit share of Qualcomm and MediaTek increased by 1.8pts and 2.1pts MoM, respectively, primarily as non-Apple/Huawei OEMs gained share sequentially. On a YoY basis, Qualcomm lost 10.4% unit share, likely to Huawei (Hisilicon), Apple, and MediaTek (Exhibit 29 - Exhibit 30). MediaTek's shipment mix continued to improve slightly in June after plateauing for 2-3 quarters (Exhibit 31).

- Exhibit 29 also shows that while YTD Qualcomm has been suffering share loss vs. the same period last year, MediaTek has been able to successfully keep its share comparable vs. last year, thanks to the share gain in RMB 2,000 -4,000 price band and particularly in Xiaomi and Honor (Exhibit 32 - Exhibit 33). This should surprise many investors as they assume that memory squeezing low-end segment will hurt MediaTek more than Qualcomm. MediaTek expects further growth of its flagship SoC business driven by customers' oversea expansion as OEMs like OPPO and Xiaomi try to sell more high-end phones outside China (more details in our ***Tech Tour notes***). For example, Xiaomi's 17T - flagship specially targeting oversea markets has MediaTek as its sole SoC supplier (i.e. Dimensity 8500 for Standard variant & Dimensity 9500 for Pro variant). Initial feedback was generally positive, but it remains to be seen whether overseas markets can provide a sustained uplift to MediaTek's sales mix. Overall, we're cautious on MediaTek's smartphone business considering the pressure from high memory price & its higher exposure to mid- to low-end segments.

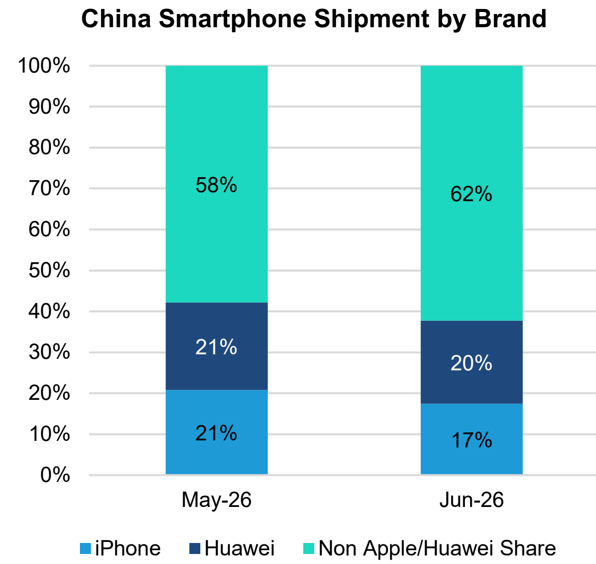
- Finally, UNISOC's share remained well below 1% (Exhibit 34), implying the mobile SoC market in China remains a duopoly. Because China has the motivation to use the chips from Chinese suppliers, UNISOC's share staying so low in China attests that the company is not competitive in 5G.

EXHIBIT 29: **In June, unit share of Qualcomm and MediaTek regained c. 2pts unit share MoM, respectively.**



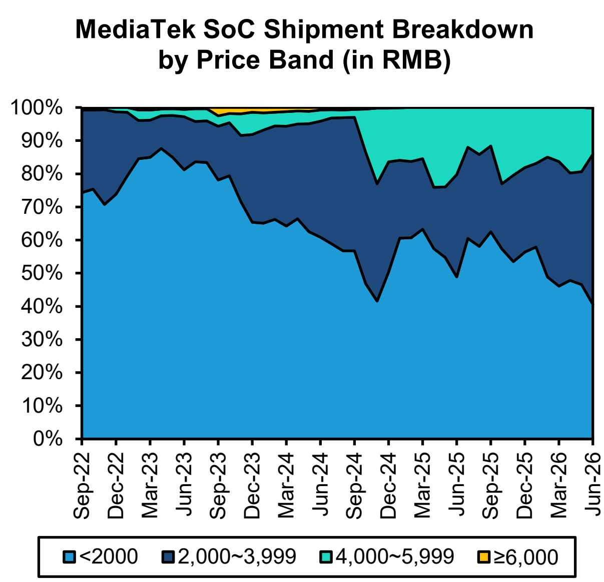
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 30: **...likely thanks to higher unit share of non-Apple/Huawei OEMs.**



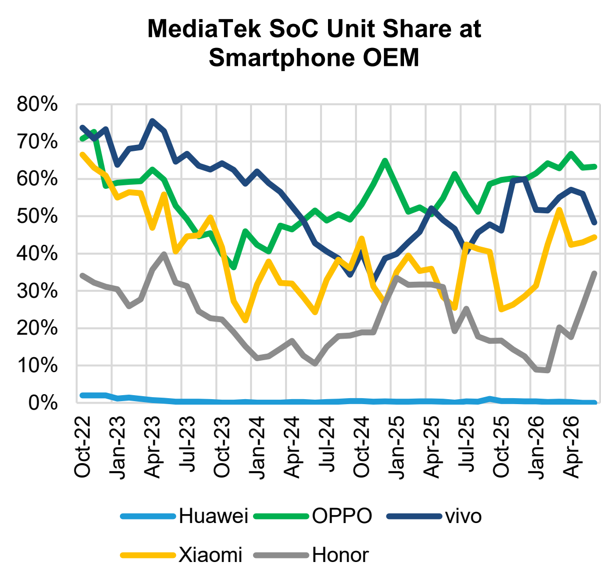
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 31: **MediaTek's shipment mix continued to improve after plateauing for a while.**



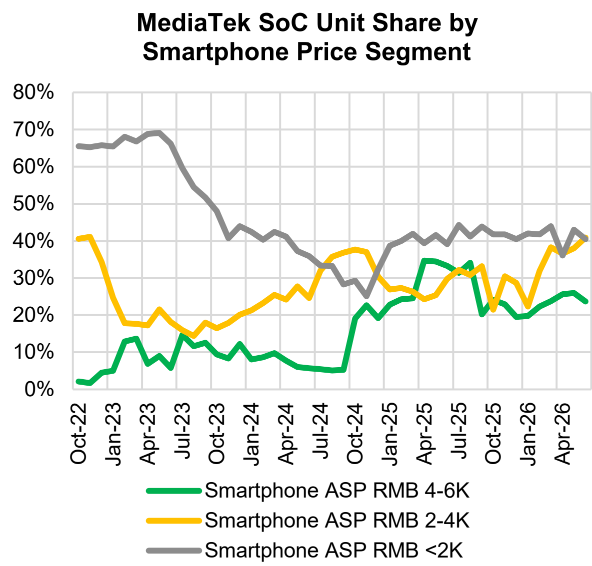
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 32: **MediaTek saw a notably share gain in Xiaomi and Honor over the past 6 months.**



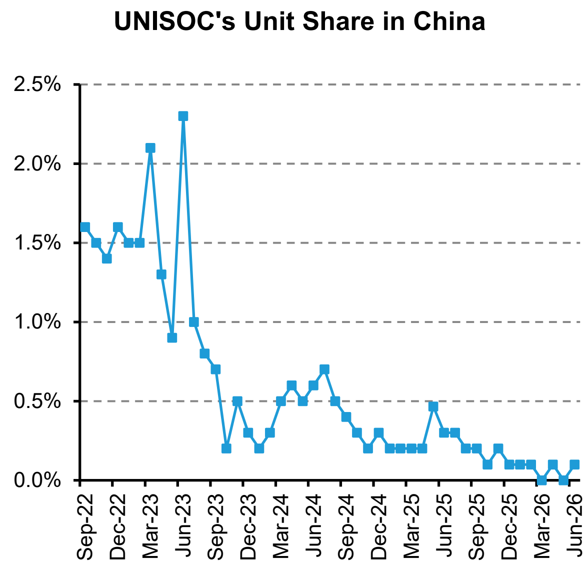
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 33: **By price tier, MediaTek gained unit share in mid-end smartphone market YTD.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 34: **UNISOC's share remained very small in China, indicating UNISOC is not competitive in 5G.**



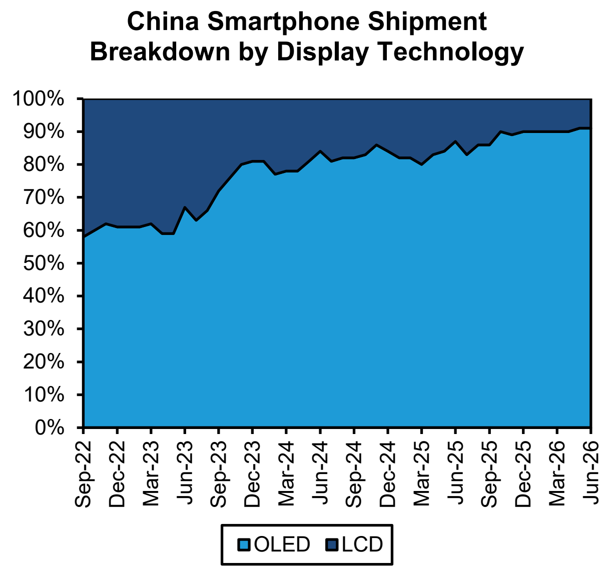
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

OLED helps Novatek fend off the Chinese rivals, but the adoption has hit a ceiling. Foldable panel remained too small to move the needle.

- After OLED panel penetration surpassed 80% of the smartphones shipped in China in late 2023, further penetration has been very gradual (Exhibit 35). In fact the penetration has been hovering around 90% for months, indicating that OLED is a mainstream feature and offers very limited further growth headroom (Exhibit 36, Exhibit 37). The growth of OLED panel and the supporting DDIC is thus bound to slow. Novatek has been a key beneficiary of the rising OLED adoption but plateauing OLED penetration may allow Chinese rivals to catch up. Going forward, Novatek will need to count on share gains especially at Apple & Samsung & the integration of touch function to OLED DDIC to sustain growth & its competitiveness vs. Chinese rivals.

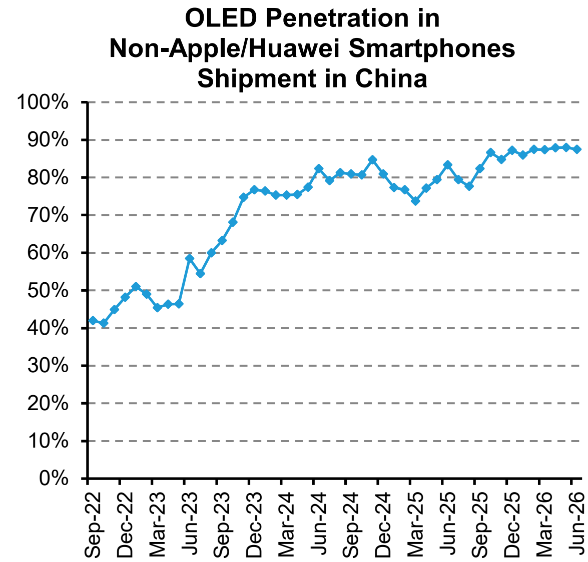
- Finally, foldable panel adoption dropped to below 2% in June (Exhibit 38). We don't expect a meaningful pick-up in the penetration until late 2026 when iPhone Foldable is expected to debut.

EXHIBIT 35: **The OLED penetration stood at c. 90% in June.**



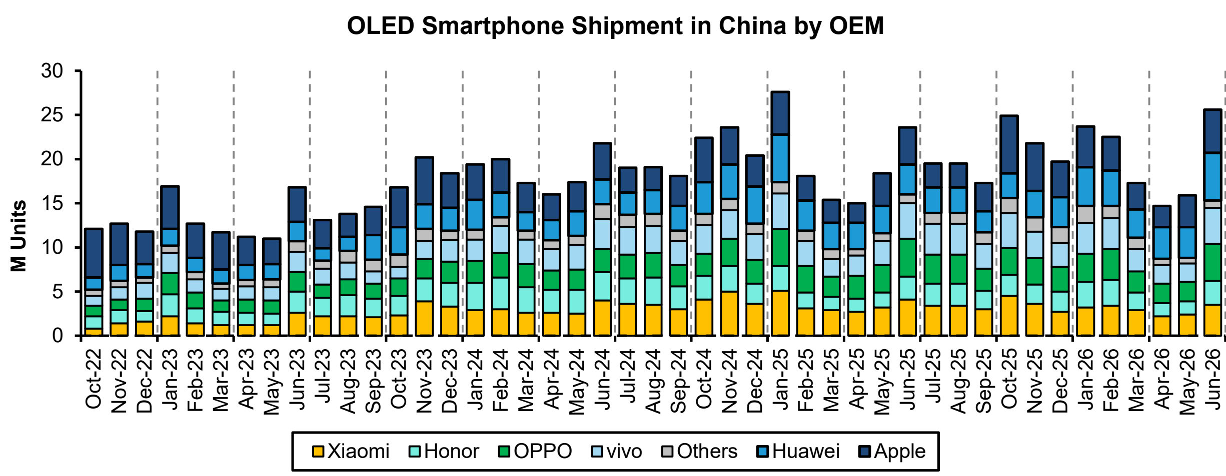
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 36: **OLED penetration in non-Apple/Huawei smartphones remained at high-80s%.**



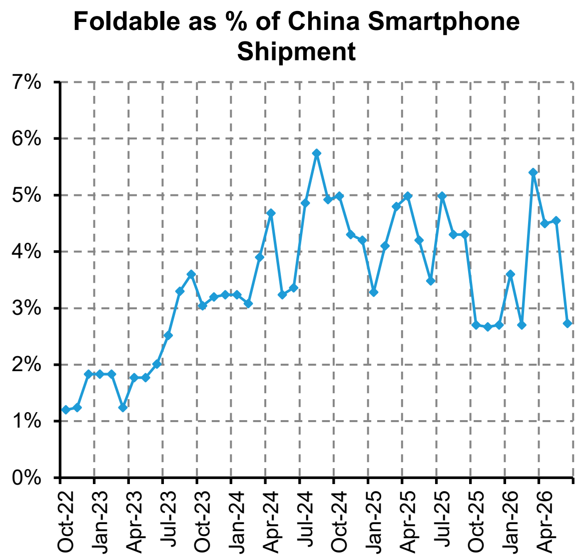
Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 37: **Huawei and Apple shipped notably more OLED YoY in June.**



Source: CINNO and Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 38: **The adoption rate of foldable panel dropped below 2% in June.**



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